

AI AGENTS IN SALES

I Built an AI Agent That Researches My Sales Accounts

Salesforce + n8n + Claude: a pre-call brief that writes itself

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25 years in CRM, RevOps, and GTM systems

Demo using publicly available information about TJX. No affiliation with or endorsement by the companies shown. Clockstone Systems is fictional.



The Problem: Research Before Every Call



It's manual

Reps open ten tabs, skim news and earnings, and piece together a story.



It's inconsistent

Every rep researches differently, so call quality varies.



It gets skipped

On a busy day, prep is the first thing to go.

The goal

A research brief waiting in the account before the rep ever opens it.

No extra clicks. No new tool to learn. It lives where reps already work.

What the Agent Does

Every hour, the agent finds Salesforce accounts that don't have a brief yet. For each one, Claude runs its own web research, fact-checks the draft, and writes a formatted brief back into the account.

3

fields in

Name, website, and ticker. That's all it starts with.

14

web searches, max

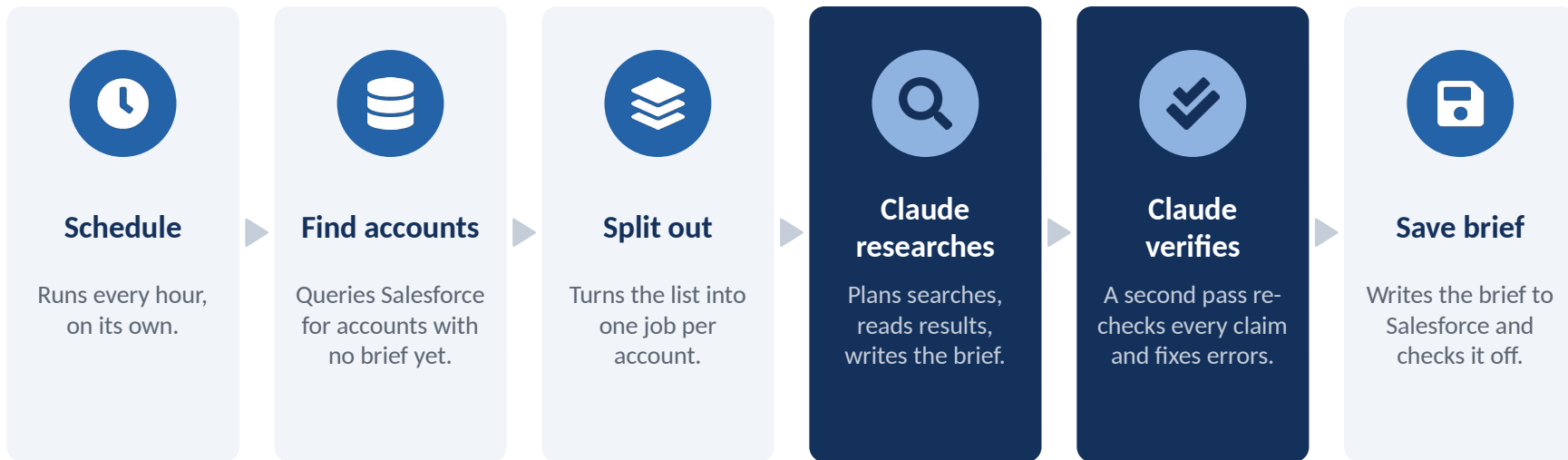
Up to 8 to research and 6 more to fact-check. Claude picks each one.

1

brief out

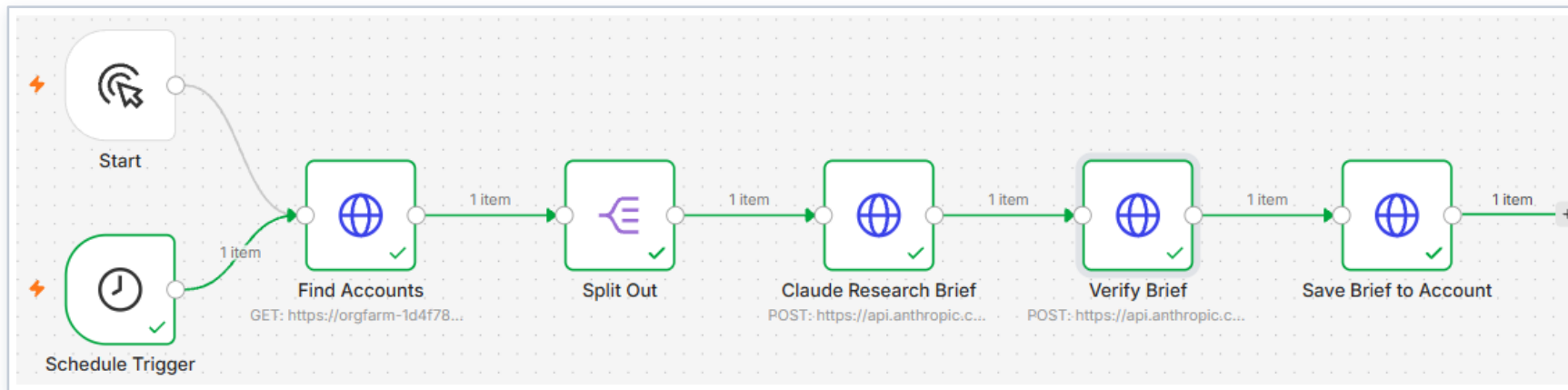
Formatted, sourced, and saved to the account record.

How It Works: Six Steps in n8n



Built-in safeguard: after saving, the agent checks a “Brief Generated” box, so the next run skips that account and never pays to research it twice.

The Real Workflow in n8n



Two triggers

Start runs it by hand for testing and demos. Schedule Trigger runs it every hour once published.

Find + split

One Salesforce query returns accounts with no brief. Split Out makes each one its own job.

Research, verify, save

Three HTTP calls: Claude researches, a second Claude call fact-checks, Salesforce saves.

Why It's an Agent, Not a Script



What Claude chose to search for TJX

1. "TJX Companies news"
2. "TJX second quarter fiscal 2027 results"
3. "TJX Companies 2026 expansion supply chain technology"
4. "TJX Marshalls HomeGoods expansion"

Nobody wrote those queries. Claude picked each one based on what the last search turned up. The workflow around it is fixed; the research inside it is not. The industry term is an agentic workflow.

The Stack



Salesforce

Developer Edition

System of record.
Accounts go in, briefs
come back. Free.



n8n

Workflow engine

Schedule, query, loop,
and connect the APIs.
14-day cloud trial; free
to self-host.



Claude API

Sonnet + web search

Researches and writes
the brief as HTML, then
a second call fact-checks
it.



Authentication

Client credentials

How n8n logs into
Salesforce. The standard
login was blocked by
PKCE.

Simple Start: The First Brief

Research Brief

PRE-CALL BRIEF: TJX Companies (TJX)

WHAT THEY DO

TJX is a Fortune 100 company and the leading off-price retailer of apparel and home fashions in the U.S. and worldwide. Based in Framingham, it owns T.J. Maxx, Marshalls, HomeGoods, Homesense and Sierra, with 5,285 stores across 10 countries as of early August.

RECENT NEWS

- August 2026: Q2 comps rose 4%, above plan, and the company raised full-year profit margin and EPS guidance, showing financial strength. [Source](#)
- August 2026: Long-term store target raised to 7,500, with openings accelerating to 4% growth next fiscal year, so build-out demand will persist. [Source](#)
- August 2026: Marmaxx comps rose just 1% while HomeGoods, Canada and International delivered 6% to 7%, making core US apparel a pressure point. [Source](#)
- September 2026: Declared a \$0.48 quarterly dividend and added United Rentals executive Craig Pintoff to the board, signaling steady governance. [Source](#)
- May 2026: Q1 FY27 comps rose 6% and EPS was \$1.19, up 29%; full-year guidance was raised, showing strong momentum. [Source](#)

LIKELY PRIORITIES

- Fixing Marmaxx execution while HomeGoods, Canada and International keep gaining.
- Funding faster store growth toward 7,500 stores, with growth rising to 4% from FY28.
- Protecting margins, since labor and sourcing costs could outpace what pricing and mix recoup.

TALKING POINTS

1. Show how you support a bigger footprint: store openings accelerating to 4% growth.
2. Link your offering to speeding up Marmaxx's recovery, where comps are lagging other divisions.
3. Frame your value as protecting margin, given cost pressure risk and one-time tariff refund benefits.

DISCOVERY QUESTIONS

1. What is most limiting Marmaxx's recovery right now, and who owns fixing it?
2. As store growth accelerates to 4%, which functions or systems are most strained?

Input

Name, website, ticker

Output

What they do, recent news, priorities, talking points, discovery questions

Proof

Every news item links to its source

Checking the Work: TJX Fact-Check

Claim in the brief	Status	What the source says
5,285 stores in 10 countries	Verified	As of Aug 1, 2026 (Q2 FY27 release)
Q2 comps +4%, above plan; guidance raised	Verified	Full-year margin and EPS guidance raised
Marmaxx +1%; HomeGoods, Canada, International +6% to 7%	Verified	HomeGoods +7%, Canada +6%, International +7%
Store target raised to 7,500; 4% growth from FY28	Verified	Up from 7,000; announced Aug 19, 2026
Q1 FY27 comps +6%, EPS \$1.19 (+29%)	Verified	May 20, 2026 release
Craig Pintoff joined the board	Verified	Announced Sept 18, 2026
\$0.48 dividend declared in September	Date off	Declared June 9; paid Sept 3, 2026
Q2 profit beat shows financial strength	Missing context	Includes a \$219M net one-time tariff refund

Sources: TJX Q1 and Q2 FY27 earnings releases; TJX dividend notice (Business Wire, June 9, 2026); FashionUnited, Sept 18, 2026.

Meet Clockstone Systems (Our Fictional Seller)



Clockstone Systems

Time, scheduling, and payroll for employers with large hourly, multi-location workforces.

Who we sell to

Mid-size and large employers in retail, manufacturing, healthcare, and logistics. Buyers: payroll, HR, and operations leaders.



Time and attendance

Clock-ins, timecards, and attendance policies across every location



Scheduling

Demand-based schedules with predictive scheduling and fair-workweek rules



Payroll

Accurate pay from approved time, with multi-state tax handling



Compliance and analytics

Union and labor-law rules, audit trails, and labor-vs-sales reporting

Clockstone Systems is made up for this demo. Its description is the seller context the agent uses.

Added More: Teaching It What I Sell

Seller context I added

“We sell HR, payroll, and time & attendance software to mid-size and large employers with large hourly or multi-location workforces.”

One sentence changed the whole brief.



Workforce profile

Headcount, hourly mix, locations, unions



Current systems

HR, payroll, and timekeeping tools, with evidence



Competitors

Who they compete with and recent moves



Industry changes

Labor, regulation, and technology shifts



Pain points

Hypotheses for the rep to test on the call



Best-fit solution

Which product area fits, and why

Adding a Second Agent: The Fact-Checker

Before: one agent

- 2 of 8 TJX claims needed a fix or more context
- Store counts contradicted each other
- Old news from 2025 slipped in
- Claude's own narration got saved into the brief

After: researcher + fact-checker

- Every figure I checked matched TJX's filings
- Most sources are SEC filings or TJX's own releases
- Store and employee counts agree across sections
- Timestamped, with no narration

One catch: the first fact-checker was too strict. It deleted Workday, Kronos, and Oracle because they aren't in SEC filings. I told it job postings count as evidence for that section.

The Verified TJX Brief, Part 1: Who They Are

Research Brief

Last updated: Oct 2, 2026 at 4:25 PM EDT

PRE-CALL BRIEF: TJX Companies (TJX)

WHAT THEY DO

TJX is the leading off-price apparel and home fashions retailer in the U.S. and worldwide. It operates T.J. Maxx, Marshalls, HomeGoods, Homesense and Sierra in the U.S., Winners in Canada, and TK Maxx in Europe and Australia.

WORKFORCE PROFILE

- About 377,000 Associates as of January 31, 2026, many working fewer than 40 hours per week. [SEC Form 10-K](#)
- About 86% work in retail stores. TJX hires thousands of temporary employees yearly, peaking at back-to-school and holiday.
- Over 5,200 retail stores globally as of January 31, 2026. Distribution centers span six countries.
- Many US and Canada distribution Associates are under collective bargaining agreements; European Associates are in works councils.

CURRENT HR / PAYROLL / TIME SYSTEMS

- Workday, HRIS/HCM: a job posting cites Core HCM, Absence and Payroll modules, plus external payroll vendors. [ZipRecruiter](#)
- Kronos, time/payroll: HR postings prefer knowledge of "Kronos and Oracle" HRIS and payroll systems. Version unconfirmed. [Indeed](#)
- Oracle, payroll/HRIS: postings list "payroll/HRIS systems (Kronos, Oracle)". [WayUp](#)
- Time and attendance payroll system, timekeeping: DC HR staff edit and audit timecards and process attendance warnings. [Workopia](#)

RECENT NEWS

- Aug 2026: TJX received \$331 million in tariff refunds and accrued incremental expenses of \$112 million for year-end incentive compensation and discretionary bonuses for eligible associates globally. Matters: large global payout and incentive accuracy. [SEC Form 8-K press release](#)
- Aug 2026: Adjusted SG&A was 19.7% of sales in Q2, 20 basis points unfavorable due to higher store wage and payroll costs. Matters: labor cost control is a live margin issue. [TJX Q2 FY27 earnings call summary \(TradingKey\)](#)
- Aug 2026: TJX plans to increase store growth to 4% beginning in FY28 and increased its long-term global store target to 7,500 stores. Matters: more hiring, scheduling and onboarding volume. [TJX Q2 FY27 earnings release](#)

COMPETITORS

- Ross Stores: 1,904 Ross locations and 363 dd's DISCOUNTS stores as of January 31, 2026. U.S.-only. No recent workforce move found. [SEC Form 10-K \(Ross\)](#)
- Burlington: smaller, fast-growing. It opened 104 net new stores in fiscal 2025, executing a long-term strategy to reach 2,000 total locations. [Yahoo Finance](#)

1

Timestamped and clean

Date and time at the top. No narration, no code marks.

2

Workforce profile

377,000 associates, 86% in stores, union contracts in distribution. All match the 10-K.

3

Current systems

Workday, Kronos, and Oracle, each backed by a linked job posting.

4

News that matters to us

Tariff refunds, wage costs, and store growth, mostly sourced to TJX's own filings.

The Verified TJX Brief, Part 2: Where We Fit

INDUSTRY CHANGES

- Predictive scheduling (fair workweek) laws: a growing compliance challenge for retailers. Matters: part-time-heavy stores face scheduling risk. [Fisher Phillips](#)
- Tariff-refund windfalls: Williams Sonoma and TJX plan to give millions of dollars in tariff refunds back to employees through 401(k) payments and bonuses. Matters: in March, U.S. Trade Representative Jamieson Greer urged companies to share the funds with workers, raising payout administration. [Fortune](#)

POTENTIAL PAIN POINTS

- Fragmented HR, payroll and time stack: Workday, Kronos and Oracle appear across postings. Hypothesis: heavy integration and reconciliation work.
- Manual HR and payroll admin at sites: DC postings cite timecard edits and attendance warnings. Hypothesis: error-prone, costly processes.
- Scheduling compliance at scale: over 5,200 stores, many part-time Associates, and growing predictive-scheduling requirements. Hypothesis: predictability-pay and notice risk.
- Labor cost control: higher store wage and payroll costs weighed on the Q2 SG&A ratio. Hypothesis: limited labor-spend visibility during growth to 7,500 stores.

BEST-FIT SOLUTION

Lead with time and attendance plus scheduling, tied to payroll accuracy and compliance. TJX has a large, part-time-heavy store workforce, many DC Associates under collective bargaining agreements, works councils in Europe, and Kronos and Oracle named in its postings. A unified timekeeping-to-payroll layer could cut manual admin and scheduling risk, and complement Workday HCM.

TALKING POINTS

1. With store growth heading toward 7,500 stores, how do you keep scheduling and timekeeping consistent across stores, DCs and countries?
2. Store wage and payroll costs are on your radar. We help managers see labor spend against sales in real time.
3. We pair time data with payroll, so union rules, works councils and fair workweek requirements are applied automatically.

DISCOVERY QUESTIONS

1. How do Workday, Kronos and Oracle fit together for time, payroll and HR today, and where do hourly Associates see friction?
2. How much manual effort goes into timecard edits, attendance points and pay corrections at stores and distribution centers?
3. How do you track schedule-change notice and premium pay across jurisdictions, and has any location been audited?

1

Industry changes

Predictive scheduling laws, and retailers sharing tariff refunds with workers.

2

Pain points as hypotheses

Each one is labeled a hypothesis and tied to the signal behind it.

3

Best-fit solution

Time and attendance plus scheduling, tied to payroll, alongside Workday.

4

Discovery questions

Built to test the pain points on the call, not to pitch.

How to Take It Even Further

Today the agent only knows the public web. The next step is giving it what your company already knows.



Sales playbooks

Messaging and plays for each segment



Product details

Features, proof points, and pricing angles



Internal CRM data

Open opportunities, contacts, and past activity



Prior emails

What's already been said to this account



Attached documents

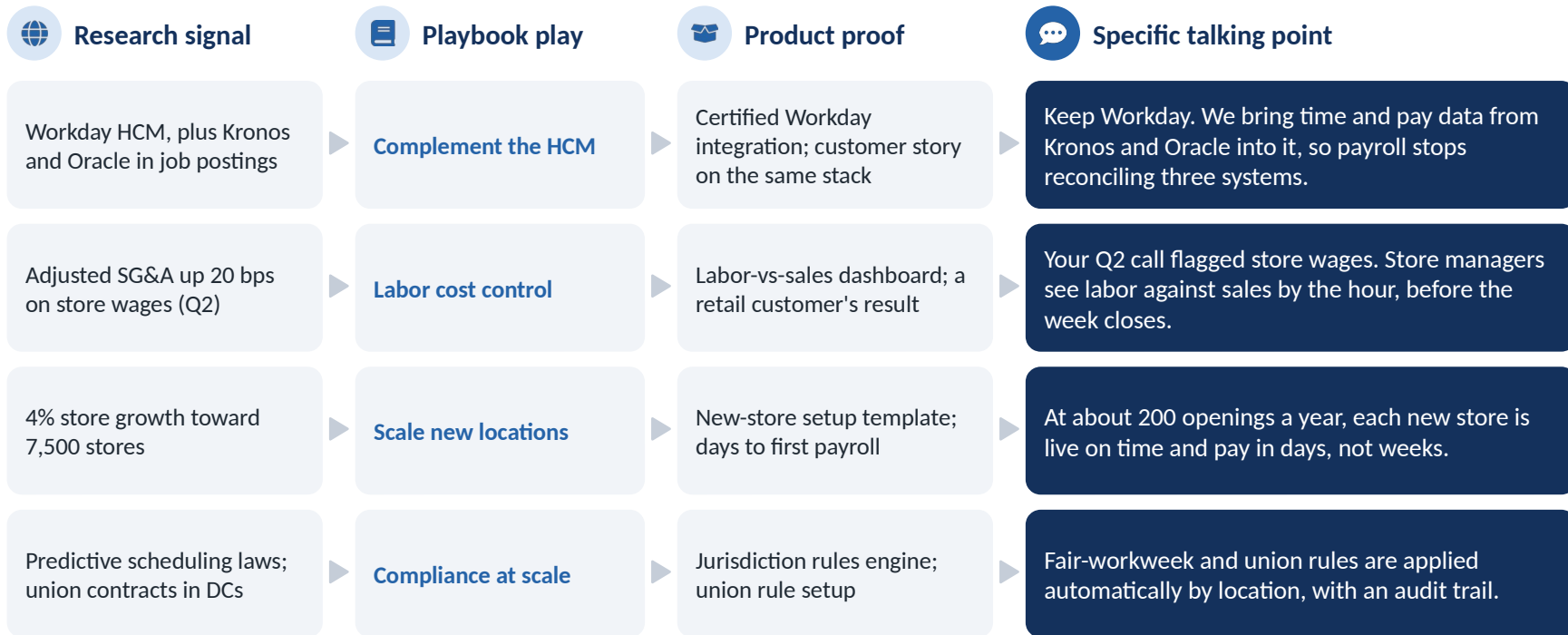
Proposals, notes, and call recaps



Memory

Report what changed since the last brief

Future State: Playbook-Driven Talking Points



TJX signals come from the verified brief. Plays and proof points are illustrative; in practice they come from your own playbook and product content.

Future State: Directing the Rep's Research

Whatever the agent can't confirm becomes the rep's to-do list, with the playbook deciding what matters for this stage of the deal.



Verify before the call

- Which Kronos version, and is it cloud or on-premises?
- Is the Workday payroll module live, or only HCM?
- Any past opportunities or closed-lost reasons in the CRM?



Find the right people

- VP of Payroll and the HRIS leader, per the playbook's buyer map
- Recent workforce management hires on LinkedIn
- Our customers who know TJX's team



Bring to the call

- Customer story on a Workday plus Kronos stack
- ROI calculator, pre-filled with store count and headcount
- Two discovery questions for the payroll persona

The shift: the agent does the legwork, and points the rep's time at what only a person can find out.

What I Learned

1

The AI was the easy part.

I spent most of a day on Salesforce authentication. New security defaults blocked the standard login, so I switched to a client credentials setup.

2

Garbage in, garbage out still applies.

My first query pulled Salesforce's fictional sample accounts. The agent would have written confident briefs about companies that don't exist.

3

You still have to check the work.

The briefs are good, but I click through the sources before I trust a number. Two of eight TJX claims needed a fix, so I added a fact-checker step.

4

Cost is real.

A fully fact-checked TJX brief cost 64 cents. Cheap for one account, real money across a whole CRM, so point it at the accounts that matter.

How to Spot a Process Worth Automating

Five questions to ask before you build

How this agent scores

1

Does it touch a core activity?

Value comes from a few core activities. Improve those first.



Pre-call prep drives sales, the core of revenue.

2

Is it repetitive and describable?

If you can write the steps down, an agent can follow them.



Same research steps, every account.

3

Is the right data available?

An AI system is only as good as its data.



Three CRM fields plus the public web.

4

Can someone act on the output?

Useful beats impressive. Insights should lead to action.



Talking points a rep uses on the next call.

5

Where does a human stay in the loop?

Keep automation high and human control high.



The rep reviews it; pain points stay hypotheses.

Drawn from my Northeastern AI coursework: value chain analysis, problem identification, and human-centered AI design.

THE TAKEAWAY

Start with the right process. Then build the agent.

Built with Salesforce, n8n, and Claude

Questions? Drop them in the comments.



Core to the business



Repeatable



Data-ready



Actionable



Human in the loop